

Short answers and language analysis

Paper 1 • Question 3 • 20 marks | syllabus 2027-2029

What you will learn

Explain meaning and analyse how imagery, sound, contrast and sentence choices shape atmosphere.

How this assessment works

All candidates take Paper 1. Centres then enter candidates for Paper 2 or the Coursework Portfolio. Speaking and Listening is optional and separately endorsed. The supplied June 2026 papers inform presentation only; question structure and word limits in this guide follow the 2027-2029 syllabus.

Short answers about words in context

A word has a dictionary meaning and a meaning shaped by its sentence. For a two-mark explanation of a phrase, communicate both relevant parts in your own words. Read before and after the quoted words to avoid guessing.

Worked example

“A reluctant sigh” describes the slow noise of the opening door [1] and makes the glasshouse feel old or resistant to being entered [1].

Language analysis: choice → association → effect

Choose brief quotations that give you something to analyse. Explain how each choice works in context and what impression it creates. Link separate examples to the changing mood; do not simply list literary devices. For this syllabus, the developed language task is about 200-250 words and carries 10 marks.

Worked example

“Each drop struck ... with the measured patience of a clock” personifies the sound and suggests regular, unsettling waiting; it intensifies the narrator’s awareness of time and isolation.

Practice paper

Short answers and language analysis

All passages and questions in this FagusED practice are original. Write in English. Marks appear in square brackets. Use the lines provided; extra paper may be attached if required.

Name: _____

Date: _____

Quick check • FagusED diagnostic (outside the Cambridge paper)

A brief study check; the official 0500 written papers use structured and extended answers.

Which comment analyses an effect?

A It uses imagery

B The bird is black

C The ticking comparison makes waiting tense and precise

D The paragraph has six sentences

Reading text

I reached the old glasshouse just as the rain began to drum on its roof. Through the misted panes I could see rows of wooden shelves and pots no larger than teacups. The door gave a reluctant sigh when I pushed it. Inside, warm air smelled of damp soil and oranges.

The caretaker had told me to fetch the seed trays before the storm grew worse. He had not mentioned that the central path narrowed between leaning towers of empty pots. Water was gathering beneath a cracked pane; each drop struck the same bucket with the measured patience of a clock. I stepped carefully, aware that the glass above me trembled whenever the wind changed direction.

At the far end stood a small lemon tree. One fruit glowed among the leaves like a lantern somebody had forgotten to extinguish. Beside it, the trays I needed were stacked neatly under a bench. I lifted them, then paused. From somewhere behind the shelves came a soft tapping, three quick sounds followed by silence. The caretaker had locked the outer gate after letting me in. I called out, and a blackbird burst from behind a watering can, brushing past my shoulder in a frantic flurry of feathers.

For a moment I laughed at myself. Then I noticed a square of blue sky reflected in the bucket: the rain had stopped. The glasshouse was quiet again, except for one last drop that fell, missed the bucket and darkened the path at my feet.

Questions

3(a)(i) Explain in your own words what “a reluctant sigh” suggests about the door. **[2]**

3(a)(ii) What does the narrator notice about the path and the roof? Give two details. **[2]**

3(a)(iii) Why does the narrator feel alarmed after hearing the tapping? **[2]**

3(a)(iv) Explain how the description of the bird changes the reader's understanding of the sound. **[4]**

3(b) Analyse how the writer uses language to create a changing atmosphere inside the glasshouse. Support your ideas with carefully chosen references to the text. Write about 200–250 words. **[10]**

Answers and teacher guidance

Check your response only after finishing the practice. Responses can be expressed in other valid words when their meanings are supported by the source.

3(a)(i) The door makes a slow creaking sound [1]; “reluctant” suggests it resists opening or gives the building a human response [1].

3(a)(ii) The path narrows between leaning piles of pots [1]; the glass overhead trembles in the wind [1].

3(a)(iii) The tapping comes from behind the shelves and no other person seems able to be there because the outer gate was locked [2].

3(a)(iv) At first the unexplained tapping suggests a threatening hidden presence [2]; the blackbird supplies a harmless cause and its sudden rush converts tension into surprise and relief [2].

3(b) Indicative response (sample extracts; develop to 200–250 words in the student task): The opening makes the glasshouse inviting despite the storm: warm air and the smell of soil and oranges create a sheltered, almost domestic atmosphere. That comfort is unsettled by the “reluctant sigh” of the door, which gives the building a secretive human quality. The narrowing path and “leaning towers” of pots make progress awkward and suggest instability. The dripping water has the “measured patience of a clock”; the comparison emphasises its repetitive sound and slows the moment, so the reader waits with the narrator. The lemon “glowed ... like a lantern”, briefly introducing warmth and guidance, before the unexplained “three quick sounds” break the stillness. The short report of the tapping, followed by silence, encourages suspicion. The narrator’s reminder that the gate is locked makes the possibility of another person seem unlikely, but it also makes the unexplained noise harder to dismiss. When the bird bursts out in a “frantic flurry”, energetic movement replaces quiet dread and reveals an innocent cause. Finally, the square of blue sky reflects calm after the storm, though the last drop leaves a small trace of unease. Credit precise quotation, connotations and effects across the passage [10].

Diagnostic answer

1: C

Source for assessment structure: Cambridge IGCSE First Language English 0500 syllabus for 2027–2029, <https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/718783-2027-2029-syllabus.pdf>. Original passages and questions by FagusED; June 2026 papers and mark schemes supplied by the user consulted for response layout and feedback style. This is independent study material, not an official Cambridge paper.